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Barak

The hesitant commander who led ten thousand men down Mount Tabor and is remembered for his faith.

Barak came from Kedesh in Naphtali. When Jabin king of Canaan had oppressed Israel for twenty years, the prophetess Deborah brought him God's command: gather ten thousand men at Mount Tabor, and the LORD would give Sisera into his hand. Barak agreed, but only if Deborah went with him. She went, warning that the honour would go to a woman. At her word Barak charged down the mountain, and the LORD routed Sisera's army, though Sisera died at the hand of Jael. Hebrews lists Barak among the people of faith.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Baraq</i> , "lightning"
Family	Son of Abinoam, of Kedesh-naphtali (Judges 4:6)
When	In Deborah's time; any BC date is rough
Key places	Kedesh, Mount Tabor, the Kishon, Harosheth
Key people	Deborah, Jael, Sisera, Jabin king of Canaan
Army	Ten thousand of Naphtali and Zebulun (Judges 4:6, 10)
Main passages	Judges 4–5
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

"And Deborah said unto Barak, Up; for this is the day in which the LORD hath delivered Sisera into thine hand: is not the LORD gone out before thee? So Barak went down from mount Tabor, and ten thousand men after him."

Judges 4:14, KJV

The life of Barak

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC, but any single date for Barak is rough.

At Kedesh-naphtali	● Called by Deborah Deborah sends for Barak and gives him God's command to take ten thousand men to Mount Tabor. <i>Judges 4:6–7</i>
Before the battle	● Asks Deborah to come Barak says he will go only if she goes with him. She agrees, but says the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman. <i>Judges 4:8–9</i>
At Kedesh	● Gathers the army Barak calls Zebulun and Naphtali to Kedesh, and ten thousand men go up with him and Deborah. <i>Judges 4:10</i>
From Mount Tabor	● Charges down At Deborah's word he leads his men down the mountain. The LORD throws Sisera's army into confusion before Barak's sword. <i>Judges 4:14–15</i>
To Harosheth	● Pursues the enemy Barak chases the chariots to Harosheth, and not a man of Sisera's army is left. He follows Sisera to Jael's tent and finds him dead. <i>Judges 4:16, 22</i>
That day	● Sings with Deborah Barak and Deborah sing of God's victory together. <i>Judges 5:1, 12</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Readers judge Barak's request in different ways. Some see weak faith, since Deborah said the honour would pass to a woman. Others see a wise wish to have God's prophet with him. Hebrews 11:32 names him among those who acted by faith.

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- 1 **Heard God's command.** Through Deborah, God told him where to go and whom to take. *Judges 4:6-7*
 - 2 **Asked for Deborah.** "If thou wilt go with me, then I will go; but if thou wilt not go with me, then I will not go." *Judges 4:8*
 - 3 **Raised the army.** He called ten thousand men of Zebulun and Naphtali. *Judges 4:10*
 - 4 **Went down at God's word.** When Deborah said, "Up," he left the high ground and attacked. *Judges 4:14*
 - 5 **Won the battle.** The LORD discomfited Sisera's chariots "before Barak." *Judges 4:15-16*
 - 6 **Found Sisera dead.** Jael showed him the man he was chasing, already slain. *Judges 4:22*
 - 7 **Sang God's praise.** The song calls, "arise, Barak, and lead thy captivity captive, thou son of Abinoam." *Judges 5:1, 12*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Barak.

Old Testament

Judges 4:6–24	The main account of his call and battle
Judges 5:1, 12, 15	He sings with Deborah; the song names him
1 Samuel 12:11	"Bedan"; Greek and Syriac read "Barak" (debated)
Psalms 83:9–10	The victory at the Kishon remembered in prayer
Echo: Exodus 33:15; Judges 6:36–40	Moses and Gideon also sought assurance
Echo: Ecclesiastes 4:9	"Two are better than one"

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–34	Named among those who "through faith subdued kingdoms"
Echo: Luke 10:1	Jesus sent his followers out in pairs

For discussion

- Observe:* What exact condition did Barak give Deborah, and what was her reply (Judges 4:8–9)?
- Understand:* Barak did not get the honour of killing Sisera, yet Hebrews honours his faith. What does that say about how God measures faith?
- Apply:* Barak wanted Deborah beside him. Whose presence or prayers help you obey God when you are afraid?
- Apply:* Barak had to leave the safety of Mount Tabor. What "high ground" might God be asking you to leave this week?